Treatment and Referral Decisions

Non-transport pause and checklist

- If a patient is being given a recommendation by ambulance personnel that transport to a medical facility by ambulance is not required, the crew must pause briefly to go through the non-transport checklist (below) and agree that non-transport is the right decision. If consensus is unable to be easily achieved, personnel should have a low threshold for recommending the patient is transported.
- The following non-transport checklist must be completed prior to leaving the scene:
  - The patient has been fully assessed including a set of vital signs and appropriate investigations, and
  - There are no unexplained abnormal vital signs, and
  - The EWS has been considered if EWS greater than or equal to five, or there is a vital sign in the red or blue zone, and
  - Serious illness or injury has been reasonably excluded, and
  - No red flags requiring transport to an ED are present, and
  - The patient is seen to mobilise safely (when able to normally do so), noting that if the patient is unable to mobilise there must be a minor or long-standing condition preventing this, and
  - The patient and/or caregivers have been given a verbal and written explanation of when to seek further help or advice.

Deciding where the patient should be referred

- If a patient is being referred to a medical facility, referral should be to the most appropriate medical facility considering:
  - The patient's expected healthcare requirements, including investigation and treatment, and
  - The most effective and efficient way of meeting those requirements, and
  - Specific referral and transport guidance contained within the relevant guideline.
- The patient may not require referral to an ED. It is preferable to refer the patient to a primary care facility, provided that:
  - The patient's healthcare requirements can be reasonably met at that facility, and
  - It is reasonable and practical to refer the patient to that facility.

The mode of transport

- Not all patients requiring transport to a medical facility require transport in an ambulance. It is appropriate to recommend alternative transport provided all of the following criteria are met:
  - The patient is very unlikely to require treatment or intervention during transport, and
  - The referral and transport guidance within each guideline are followed, and